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Wayback Machine Director Pushes Back on AI Scraping Fears Driving Archive Blocks

INTERNET ARCHIVE

WaybackMachine

As reported by Nieman Lablast month, some major media organizations—including The New York Times, The Guardian, and Reddit—have started blocking the Wayback Machine from archiving their sites over unfounded concerns about AI scraping.

Last week, tech writer Mike Masnick (Techdirt) explained why this is "a mistake we're going to regret for generations."

Today, Mark Graham, director of the Wayback Machine, has published a response to the Nieman Lab reporting, pushing back on the media organizations' concerns about the Wayback Machine being a backdoor to AI scraping. Graham writes:

"These concerns are understandable, but unfounded… like others on the web today, we expend significant time and effort working to prevent such abuse."

Read the post to learn how Graham is working to protect the integrity of the Wayback Machine, and why limiting web archiving threatens our shared digital history.

The Seers: Mystic Cats, Feminist Histories, and the Art of the Archive

Internet Archive's latest Artist in Residence, Cindy Rehm, has created The Seers, a project comprised of one hundred college drawings using images largely sourced from historic books at the Internet Archive. The Seers is inspired by the work of Hélène Cixous and Carolee Schneemann around their interest in the creative process, and mysticism often centered in the figure of the cat. Rehm searched historic books related to women and their feline companions including books on the history of cats in mysticism and witchcraft. For her collages, she gleaned images for their aesthetic and symbolic resonance, focusing on books related to histories of women including books on textiles and handiwork, art history, nature, cats, and other creatures.

Atelier Louise Bachelier, tentenkoot, 1920

For the format of the series, Rehm researched Internet Archive's collection of antique scrapbooks. The scrapbook is a vernacular form often associated with women and their private lives, and also shares a process relationship with collage, where small fragments are cut and pasted. Historic scrapbooks were often made using repurposed books like catalogs, ledgers, and music books. Rehm borrowed this gesture of layering fragments over a main image, as image cut outs were repeated and remixed across the series to develop a symbolic language and esoteric taxonomy.

As part of her project, Rehm created a limited-edition poster that she distributed during her participation in Public Domain Day on site at Internet Archive. Rehm gave a talk about her project and process, view the livestream recording here.

In February, Rehm will take The Seers to Automata in Los Angeles for a residency focused on extending the project to include an installation and performance. Please visit Rehm's website to view The Seers full series.

Cindy Rehm (https://www.cindyrehm.com/) is a Los Angeles-based artist and an educator. She serves as co-facilitator of the Cixous Reading Group, and is co-founder of the feminist-centered projects Craftswoman House and Feminist Love Letters. She is the founder and former director of spare room, a DIY installation space in Baltimore, MD. In 2021, she launched HEXENTEXTE, a collaborative project at the intersection of image, text and the body.

Rehm has held residencies at Performing Arts Forum in Saint Ermes, France and at Casa Lü, Mexico City. A book of her collage drawings, Transference, was released by Curious Publishing in 2022.